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Games24x7 is one of India's biggest online gaming companies



PHOTO BY HARDIK CHHABRA

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## “Hunker down and play for the long term”

### What was the problem you were grappling with?

In 2020, multiple states banned online games of skill. Within a few months, we lost over 50 per cent of our business. This was also a time when markets were flush with money and venture capitalists (VCs) were throwing cash at anyone who could spell “start-up”. This led to one of India’s hottest job markets, but we couldn’t compete. It had never been harder for us to acquire and retain talent.

### Whom did you approach for advice and why?

When I have complex issues like this, I consult my board of directors, my team, and advisors, but I rely most on my founding partner, Bhavin Pandya, because you want advice from someone with a different perspective, but who shares your values.

### What was the advice you received?

Complex business problems usually have simple solutions; the hardest part is implementation. Bhavin and I agreed that we had to be honest with the team—this was not a temporary battle. We had to fight these states in court and have these laws struck down as unconstitutional. We knew it would take time, but we were confident that we would win, and believed in our industry’s long-term growth. So the team had to hunker down with us and play for the long term.

### How effective was it in resolving the problem?

Many people left us during that difficult period, but we believe the best stayed back. Those who stayed are truly our long-term partners, and today we are proud to have a world-class team that shares our business goals, vision and passion, industry beliefs, and most importantly, the science of gaming—our operating ethos. Following the state bans in 2020, we had three victories in high courts in 2021 and early 2022, and became a unicorn in 2022, raising \$75 million at a valuation of \$2.5 billion in a very tough capital-raising environment. **BT**

—TEAM BT

Vol. 33, No. 3 for the fortnight  
January 22, 2024 to February 4, 2024.  
Released on January 22, 2024.  
Total number of pages 108 (including cover)